

Week 4: The Bible as Jewish Meditation Literature

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

Biblical stories don't always give us the details we'd expect — tonight we'll look at why, and what it means to read that kind of writing well.

1. Think of a book, film, or song you've come back to more than once and noticed something new each time. What was it, and what did repeated encounters bring out that you missed the first time around?
2. Biblical narrative often leaves out details modern readers expect — what people looked like, why they made the choices they made. Does that surprise you? Have you ever felt frustrated reading a Bible story because information seemed to be missing?
3. Take the story of Cain and Abel as an example: we're never told why God had regard for Abel's offering but not Cain's. Why might a storyteller want you to feel confused on purpose?
4. When an author leaves ambiguity in a story, different readers can honestly land on different interpretations of it. What's the risk in that kind of open-ended storytelling, and what's the potential reward?
5. **Read Psalm 1.** What does Psalm 1 say the "blessed" person avoids, and what does he do instead? The Hebrew word translated "meditate" is used elsewhere to describe a bear growling low over its prey, or a dove cooing — a quiet, absorbed sound, not an empty, silent mind. How is that picture different from what you'd typically picture when you hear the word "meditation"?
6. What would it actually look like to build a habit of delighting in and meditating on Scripture "day and night" into an ordinary week?
7. Psalm 1 compares this kind of person to "a tree planted by streams of water," steadily bearing fruit. Why do you think patient, repeated engagement with

Scripture gets compared to a slow-growing tree instead of something quicker, like a sudden flash of insight?

8. If success in reading the Bible isn't about extracting a tidy takeaway every single time, but about learning to sit with ambiguity and let a passage shape you over years, how does that change what a good "quiet time" or devotional habit might actually look like?
9. What's one story or passage you've read many times but never really slowed down to sit with? What would it look like to "meditate" on it, in the Psalm 1 sense, sometime this week?